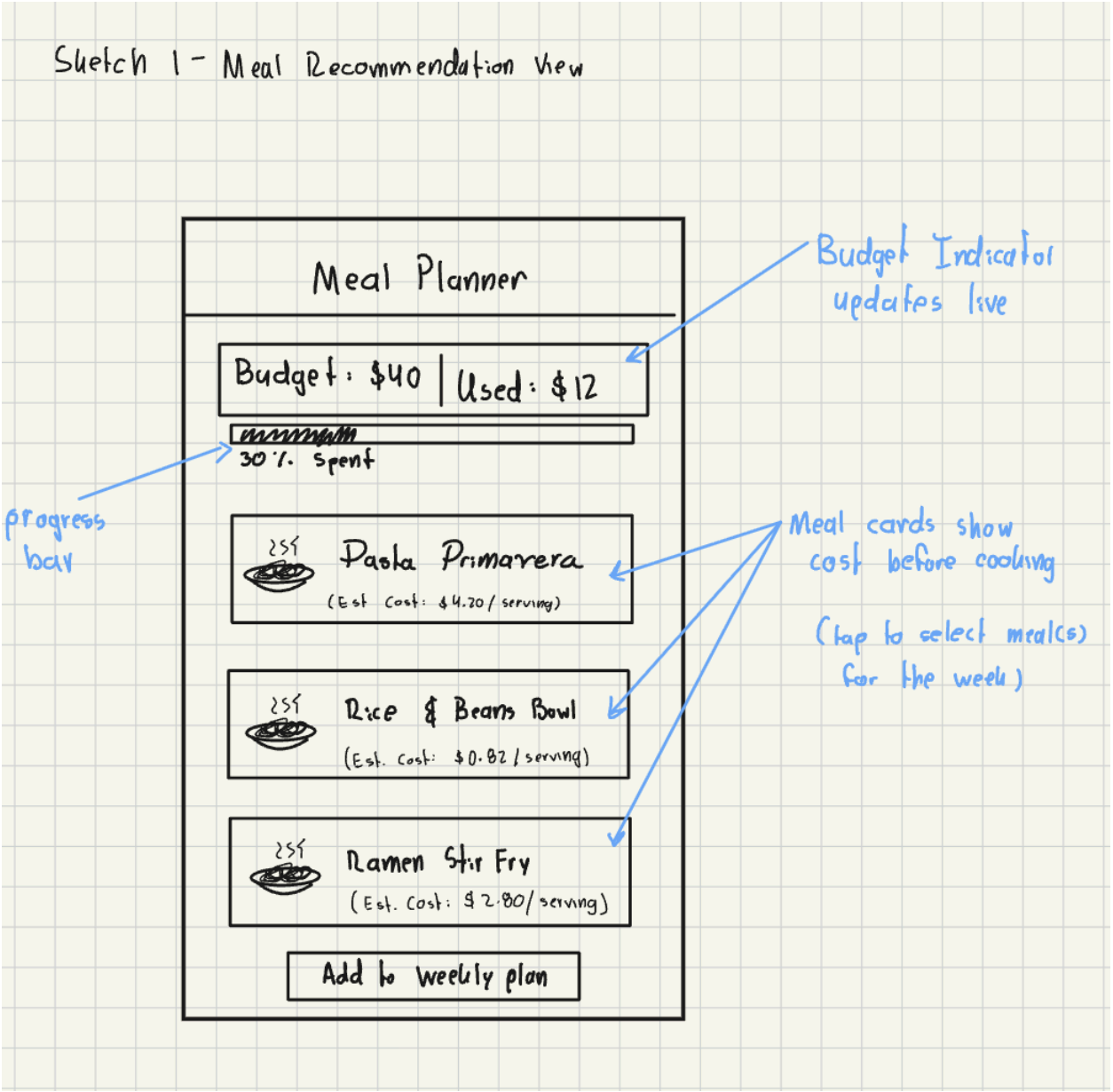
Sketches


Sketch 1 - Meal Recommendation View
Meal Planner
Budget: $40 | Used: $12
30% spent
Pasta Primavera
(Est Cost: $4.20 / serving)
Rice & Beans Bowl
(Est. Cost: $0.82 / serving)
Ramen Stir Fry
(Est. Cost: $2.80 / serving)
Add to weekly plan
Budget Indicator updates live
progress bar
Meal cards show cost before cooking
(tap to select meal(s) for the week)

Sketch 2 – Auto grocery list generator

Selected Meals

Select recipes to add relevant ingredients to shopping cart:

- [x] Pasta Primavera
- [x] Rice & Beans Bowl
- [ ] Ramen Stir fry
- [ ] Egg Fried Rice

Projected Cost
(for 7 servings of each

Generate List

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Grocery List

Check pantry and remove what you already have:

Produce (Remove)

- [ ] 1 bulb garlic ⊖
- [ ] 1 bell pepper ⊖
- [ ] 1 onion ⊖

Pantry

- [ ] 24 oz pasta ⊖
- [ ] 3 12oz can black beans ⊖
- [ ] 1 lb rice ⊖

Protein

- [ ] 12 Eggs (large) ⊖

Portions ⊖ 14 ⊕

Projected cost $32.00

$28.00

ability to add or remove items from produced grocery list based on pantry survey

Sketch 3- Smart Budget + substitution tool

My Grocery List

Budget: $40 | Current: $38

☐ Chicken breast: $6.50

→ store brand: $4.50 (-$2)

swap | keep

☐ Milk (name brand): $4.99

→ On sale @ Walmart: $2.99

☐ Eggs : $2.79

☐ Rice : $4.10

☐ Garlic : $1.50

total savings available - $4.00

Apply suggestions & swaps

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real time budget tracker

notif f/ price saving swap

shows potential savings

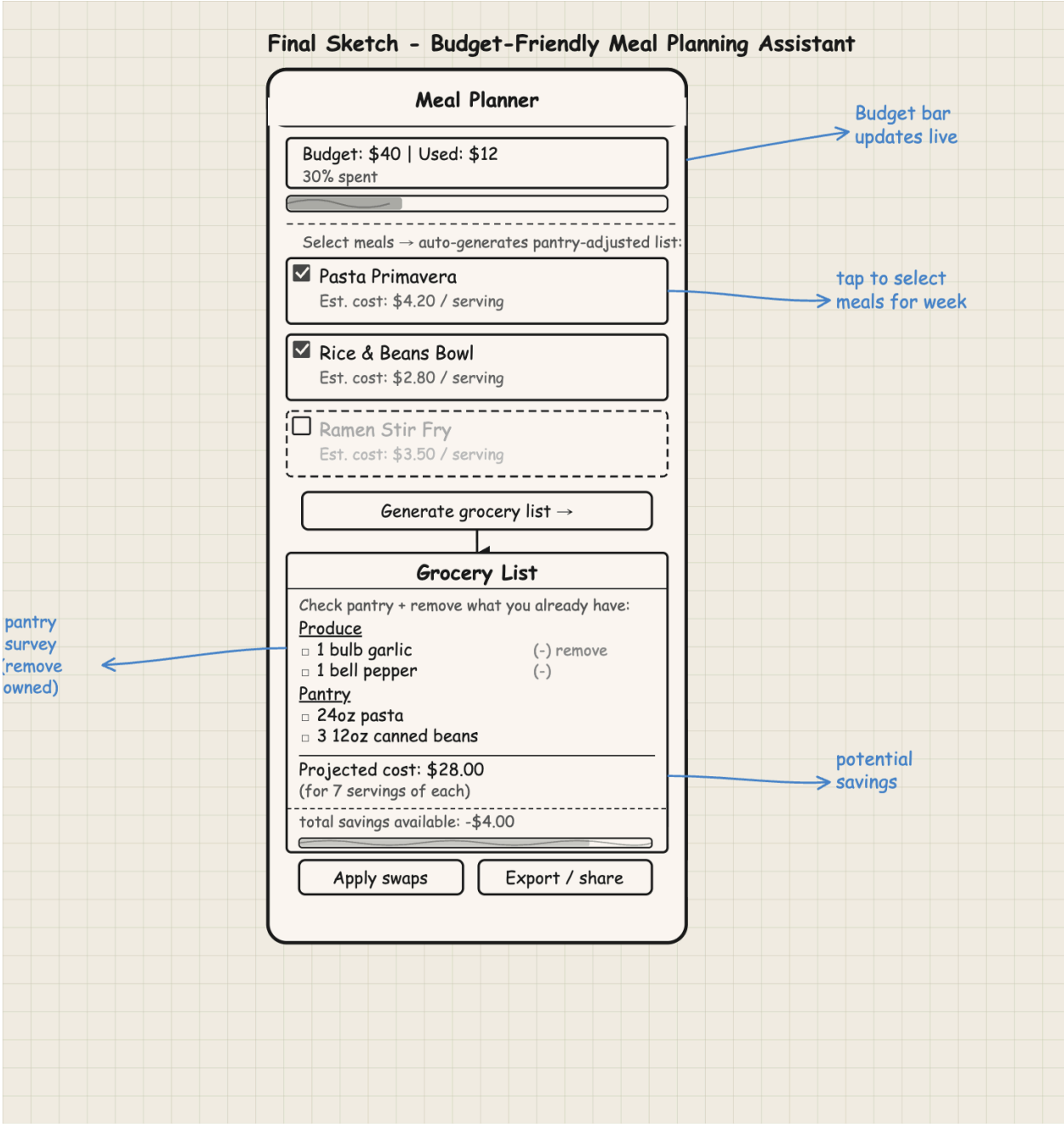
Feedback

Hey! I really like your Sketch 2 — the pantry survey idea where you can remove items you already have at home is something I didn't think of in my designs, and it's super practical for college students who already have rice or pasta sitting around. Your two-panel layout (Selected Meals → Grocery List) is really clear and easy to follow. One thought: your Sketch 3 is really similar to my Design 3 since we both did the dashed substitution boxes and swap/keep buttons — it might be cool to differentiate it a bit, like maybe showing the substitutions as a separate "savings summary" screen instead of inline?

Final Sketch

Budget-Friendly Meal Planning Assistant

This design concept focuses on helping college students plan meals, generate grocery lists, and stay within budget. The system integrates meal recommendations, automatic grocery list generation, and real-time budget tracking to reduce cognitive effort and make grocery shopping more efficient and affordable.



Feedback:

- One teammate highlighted that the pantry survey feature in Sketch 2 was especially useful, since many students already have staple items like rice or pasta at home. This helped reinforce the importance of allowing users to remove items from the generated grocery list.
- Another piece of feedback was that the transition from meal selection to grocery list generation was clear and intuitive, especially in the two-panel layout.
- A suggestion for improvement was to differentiate the substitution feature in Sketch 3. Since similar designs used inline swap boxes, it was recommended that we explore

alternative ways of presenting savings, such as a summary view or a clearer savings indicator.

TL;DR: I need to prioritize clarity, practicality, and reducing user effort.

Final Sketch Description:
The final sketch combines the strongest elements from the three initial designs into a single, cohesive interface. It integrates meal selection, automatic grocery list generation, and real-time budget tracking into one streamlined flow. Based on feedback, we emphasized the pantry-adjusted grocery list and made cost visibility more prominent through the budget bar and projected cost section. We also refined the savings feature by clearly displaying potential savings at the bottom of the grocery list, making it easier for users to understand the financial impact of their choices.

Reflection:
The critique process was helpful because it brought attention to small but important usability improvements, especially around clarity and reducing cognitive load. One thing that went well was that team members focused on both strengths and areas for improvement, which made the feedback constructive and easy to apply. A challenge was balancing multiple features without making the design too complex. In the future, we would explore more diverse layout variations earlier in the process before converging on a final design.